# Super, Simple Security

Here're some easy-to-use security tips and tools that can give you that peace of mind.

Security and privacy are two things about which everyone—from netbook owners to server administrators—is concerned. After all, it is one of the main reasons why people switch over to Linux and other FLOSS software. But once they do switch over, they find it to be a very daunting task to actually get started with encrypting hard drive partitions, ensuring privacy, etc. Many people are scared of the terminal, the cryptic commands and the terminology that they need to get familiar with in order to secure themselves.

Well, if you are new to all this, relax. In this article we will look at ways of securely performing some of the most common tasks on our computers; and do so in a very simple and user-friendly manner.

## Home directory encryption

Most of you probably know about the possibility of encrypting your data to make it secure. But I'm sure only a few of you might actually use this feature on your system. The main reason for this might be the lack of know-how or the negative impact on performance due to encryption and decryption of the entire system.

The recently-released Ubuntu 9.10, Karmic Koala, solves both these problems with a very nifty feature—a per-user home directory encryption. While home directory encryption was present in the past few versions of Ubuntu, it was never this simple to set up. This feature uses the eCryptfs cryptographic filesystem. The fact that the encryption is done only for the home directory and not the entire filesystem, means that it encrypts the data that is most important to you, while causing minimum degradation in performance. Some estimate the performance loss to be around 5 per cent.

How it works is extremely simple. You can set it up during installation from the GUI installer itself. Figure 1 shows the steps in the installation process. Once set up, whenever we boot the computer and log in, the directory is unlocked and we can use it just as we would normally use our home directory. It must also be noted that if you enable home directory encryption, then encrypted swap is also set up from this release onwards.

Now, some of you might be wondering how secure this encryption really is. Well, Dustin Kirkland (who developed this feature) says that while this might not be the best